Tales from a Child of the Enemy: Words and The Master Race

By Ursula Duba

INTRODUCTION

Ursula Duba is a non-Jewish German born in Germany shortly before the outbreak of WWII. She grew up in postwar Germany knowing nothing about the atrocities committed by her people during the War. Finally at the age of 19 she began to learn the history of Nazi Germany, and was changed forever. These poems are brutally honest in their examination of the prejudices and stereotypes of both the German and Jewish peoples.

Words

bold letters

on top of the page

declare

this newsletter is dedicated

to all those

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who perished

in the Holocaust

the German man,

now living in the USA

is proud of his efforts

to pay homage

to the victims of the Shoah

on the anniversary

of kristallnacht

but i am disturbed

by the word *perish*

in this dedication -

it conjures up images

of people dying in earth quakes

in a storm out on the open sea

in a hurricane or a tornado -

the word *perish*

does not tell me

about open ditches

rapidly filling up with the corpses

of innocent men women and children

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shot by members of the einsatzgruppen and the
Wehrmacht
it doesn't show me piles of emaciated bodies
deliberately starved to death
it doesn't show me ss guards
using victims for target practice
nor does it display the twisted bodies
of people who died
at the hands of doctors
who performed cruel experiments
in the name of science
there are no gas chambers
crematoria
or perpetrators
weren't Jews Gypsies and non-Aryans
murdered
i ask the German man
yes of course
the victims of the Holocaust
were *murdered*
he answers

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taken aback
by my question
but this word
sounds so aggressive
he says with dismay
after several days
of back and forth
on the telephone
the German man decides to delete the entire sentence
on top of the newsletter
rather than using the word *murdered*
in his dedication to the victims
of the Shoah
while discussing this
with several friends
we take note
that a lengthy article
in a leading magazine
had recently informed us
that most of the victims
of the massacres in Rwanda

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had been hacked to death
by their Hutu neighbours -
no euphemisms there
as to how these victims died
and on discussing the
three million Cambodians
who died in the killing fields -
the language is quite clear -
they were starved to death
or brutally murdered
by the Kmer Rouge
On further probing
no one suggests
that John F. Kennedy and
Martin Luther King perished -
both were *assassinated*
a few weeks later
i ask a Holocaust survivor
what words would properly describe
the actions by which
six million died

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they were *exterminated*
he says
without hesitation
this word immediately reminds me
of my first months
in an apartment in Brooklyn
and the discovery of cockroaches
in my kitchen cupboards
honey
my next door neighbour
had told me then
look in the yellow pages
under *exterminator*
recently
i heard Mike Wallace of 60 minutes
refer to all those who were *lost*
in Auschwitz
the word *lost*
makes me think
of my fear
of getting lost in foreign cities

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on my travels abroad

when even maps

are of limited value

in those countries

which use different alphabets

the word also

calls up images

of thick forests

where hapless travelers

get lost

and i am reminded of

the story of Hansel and Gretel which used to make me

appreciate

the safety of our crammed house

when i was a child

what with the twice a day roll-call

and the meticulous record keeping

of the German and Austrian concentration camp

commanders

the chance of being *lost* in Auschwitz

or any other concentration camp

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were very slim

my friend Dalia

explains to me

whose mother was gassed on the first day

of their arrival in Birkenau.

TRANSITION

Adolf Eichmann was the SS leader in charge of masterminding the transportation of Jews from all over Europe to the murder factory at Auschwitz. He was captured at the end of World War II, but managed to escape from an internment camp and disappear. In May 1960 Israeli secret service agents captured him in Argentina and smuggled him to Israel, where his trial attracted worldwide attention. Many Holocaust survivors gave detailed testimony about the horrors of the Nazi death camps. Eichmann was found guilty, sentenced to death, and hanged on May 31, 1962. The Master Race and Words by Ursula Duba from her book Tales from a Child of the Enemy focuses on the emotional issues surrounding the Holocaust and the long term effects on the children of its victims and survivors.

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The Master Race

during a brisk walk
along the shoreline
Werner tells me
how devastated he was
when classmates called him
a Nazi
during the Eichmann trial
in their new home in Chicago
to which they had emigrated
in the early fifties
from their home town Bremerhaven
in north Germany he was sixteen at the time of that
trial
had learned English well
since his arrival in 1951
and had been raised
with pride in his heritage
by his Nazi parents
even though their house in Bremerhaven

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had turned into rubble
during WWII
two uncles had died
at the Eastern front
and one in captivity in Russia
after the war
and there was nothing left
of the family business
which had supplied
.....
to the war effort
his father and mother
looked with pride
on their two sons and two daughters
all of them tall
blond
blue-eyed
and athletic
his father hardened himself
with cold showers
in the morning

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endurance was emphasized
and crying not tolerated
all of them were spurred on
to participate in vigorous and competitive sports -
let's show those soft Americans
what we Germans can do
was their father's continuous battle cry
even though his father's pipe dream
of becoming rich in America
and showing off to his impoverished family
back in Germany
was not materializing -
one scheme after another had gone bust
and Werner was ashamed
of their shabby apartment
and the hand-me-down clothes
he had to wear
his parents had no friends
and he and his siblings
were discouraged to bring classmates
back home

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because his father was suspicious
of all Americans
even the blond and blue-eyed ones
after all
Americans believed in the melting pot
he told them
you could never know
what inferior genes
were lurking in their bodies an insult to humanity
he used to call this mixing
of people from different countries
and nothing good would come out of it
he declared frequently
don't forget
he used to lecture his children
we are the master race
and far superior to anybody else
he blamed Hitler's defeat
on the Conspiracy of World Jewry
and on all those Germans who had not sufficiently
supported Hitler and The Thousand Year Reich

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when he came home
from his menial job
after washing down his schnapps with several beers
he insisted they listen to him
when he told them
about the ancient Nordic gods
who hadn't believed in weakness and mercy
and he instructed them
that only the master race
was entitled to rule the world
and that all others
were destined to do their bidding
and to obey them
during the Eichmann trial
discussed at great length
on television in the newspapers and at school
Werner was horrified
about the atrocities committed by his people
in his country
he joined a peace group in college
broke with his father

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became a teacher
and devoted himself to many worthy causes
during the next thirty years
eventually
Werner participated in a training program
to teach hard core criminals
conflict resolution
and now spends most of his free time
in a maximum security prison
I see his eyes light up
when he talks about the bonds
he has formed with those inmates
and hear his pride
in having been able
to help the prisoners learn reading and writing
besides conflict resolution
I am touched by Werner's compassion
and caring
for those prison inmates
but miss the mentioning
of the victims

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of the perpetrators

who raped assaulted and committed robberies and

murders

and what do the inmates

think of your work

I ask Werner

the tall blond blue-eyed athletic man

stops his brisk walk

for a moment

and tells me

looking at me with pride and joy

they treat us like gods

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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